Incanto – Some Lamb

By Stuart Rice

INTRODUCTION

In a grief-ridden haze after her daughter Michele died of leukemia at age 6, Anne Rice wrote her first novel Interview With the Vampire in only five weeks. As a tribute to Michelle, Rice created the character Claudia, a six-year old vampire child parented by Lestat and Louis, who is granted immortality.

"Writers write about what obsesses them. You draw those cards. I lost my mother when I was 14. My daughter died at the age of 6... When I'm writing, the darkness is always there. I go where the pain is." she explained.

After Michelle's death, Anne's husband also used writing as an outlet for his grief. . . His release came through poetry and dealt directly with the overwhelming emotions of watching your child face certain death. Incanto – Some Lamb by Stuart Rice.

1.

I sit waiting for one of the two kinds of miracle:

the thing as it *is*, or the thing *transformed* –

which Tyger?–

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

There are no lambs here, my juicy head –Time

hath made off with the last lamb left – That's dead –

Anne sits reading the Chronicle in her nightmare clothes

– Daisy

glossy on couch – I hear a broom & a hose on concrete –

my neighbor,

sweeping his reflection away, no doubt – The

photographs are in the album

each face under its plastic, waiting, for the Real, the

cheek

crushed to cheek

that the brain might arc the gulf between brains –

Orgasm? –

A huge hand comes out of the clouds and squeezes the

brain

and lets it go

and it soaks back up what it let – self drenched again –

astonished,

a mirror in grass –

Is the miracle *clarity*? – precise definitions instead of

this *song*? –

Which tyger shall eat the reflection? – If I'm to go on
the terms of the slaughter must be known –
Huge headed child lying on couch beating her lace collar
under which is the pain in her lungs –
The precise names of the medicines
did not help:
6-mercaptopurine prednisone cytoxin methotrexate
dilantin
thioguanine vincristine asparaginase cytocine-
arabanacide
NO HELP –
At 4 a.m. I wake up on hospital linoleum beside her bed
TV
hissing the screen a miracle of chaos not a single word
worth saving they're all too small throw them back no
limit
to errors the faces are under the plastic in the album
two
months have passed she's dead that's it the scissors lie
in
the moonlight on the bedstand clarity is cannibalism –

4NG Fanatics

Sunday – 8 October – 72
Michele now nothing but an emptying dress in the grave.

2.

White day – glare – light on the liars –
Outside the Rainbow Carwash & Lounge
the blacks in ankle-length leather – shoes of shame
vanished –
lightning in leather – All the names of the colors
in the 48 count box of crayolas,
listed – Clarity & Vividness joined – screamy with silky –
The books articulate, intact – poodles barking at
windows – a girl
at a curtain, reading – a white dress drying in a tree –
ruthless clockshop window & enameled scarlet chinese
porcelain egg
on crunchless velvet –
And not *one* human in the landscape who is not a
metaphor –
Everything metaphor except the metaphors – Gesture is
sculpture –

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

The swinger stands fixed in nitrogen
and the brain that talked just an hour ago shines in a jar
–
To write this right is to cope with the corpse –
I kissed her in the coffin, the big cool rubber doll in the coffin,
she smelled like crayolas, her face
a Thought –
Hold on – even in heaven, frozen in gold – in the boneyard
where the clock coughs, hold on – in the marble, safe against seepage,
hold – in the dirt, in the neutral, hold on
that you might be able,
should the miracle come,
LET GO.

3.

I let her go, I told her, me, squeezing the oxygen bag,
Electrocardiagram ink line straight to horizon, no blip,
Precision useless again, Chief Doctor

4NG Fanatics

In rumpled suit no tie unshaven 5 a.m. & fumbling Intern,
This probably his first death, mine too,
Anne in her blue robe astonished, after two years, still,
at the last moment,
ASTONISHED,
Fingers to lips,
The oxygen tent ripped back, the cooler roaring for nothing, me
Squeezing the rubber bag trying to find the rhythm of a breather sleeping
That her heart might recognize, begin again, all the time
Saying to myself "Don't come back Mouse don't come back," her head
Heavy on rubbery neck the veins I'm ASTONISHED
Rising to the surface of the skin like crazed lacquer,
One Two Three
Shots of adrenalin straight into the vein,
No response,
Me squeezing now the tears dropping bright on the black rubber bag No
Response,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

The head nurse massaging the chest a deep gurgle like a clogged trap
NO RESPONSE, Anne
"Can't we do anything, isn't there anything else we can *do*?" The Doctor
Stands up, "You can stop now, we might as well stop kidding ourselves, she's
Gone," and my head cocks sideways like the RCA Victor dog
& I bend over & her lips part easily & wetly & I give her the long kept sexual kiss of father
to daughter, too late
Hello.

4.

Enough is never enough – That voice comes back – Suave shells of gesture
in doors – The photographs just holes full of crayolas, a glare
in a book – Never enough – Anne drinks, pregnant with novel, writes & screams –

4NG Fanatics

Ten twelve fifteen beers, never enough –
Once more small voiced prophetess bald and swollen in final months in red
wheelchair spoke the truth & knew no other thing to say
& Death ate her
& Death wasn't even hungry – Well,
"when the sun goes to sleep it makes a hole in its bed" –
There was no key to lock the door no emergency shriek no police the rapist
came in under the door a crack too small even for light to get
he got – Backwards, that – Forward, Michele as a model – Meanwhile,
the poem, for a moment, voice in the gulf, the nightmare articulated, the clock
naked, its back off, blood on the toilet paper, the experience sung, done,
Incanto,
the brain squeezed then released to drink back up what it bled –
Clarity & Vividness, both miracles, wed – At last –

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

For a moment –

No more death.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Stuart Rice
Book: Singing Yet: New and Selected Poems
ISBN: 978-0679411451
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): June 1992

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY